

The Color Line: Du Bois' Global Imperative

The fight for racial equality in the U.S. is a never-ending battle dating back to the Civil War. Great leaders such as Frederick Douglass, Martin Luther King, and Malcolm X are only some of the many who have theorized how African Americans can dig themselves out of their plight. Today the conversation often focuses on national efforts of education and economic stimulation, which have shown progress thus far. What stands out however are the theories of W.E.B. Du Bois formulated in the first half of the twentieth century.

Du Bois wrote about an apparent “global color line,” stating in his 1903 book, *The Souls of Black Folk*, “The problem of the twentieth century is the problem of the color-line—the relation of the darker to the lighter races of men in Asia and Africa, in America and the islands of the sea.”¹ The idea of the global plight of colored people in the world was not something theorized on such a scale before in the field of sociology, which Du Bois himself modernized for the twentieth century. Du Bois’ concept of a global color line is even more prevalent today than at the time of its inception. In the age of the internet, we live in a hyper-globalized world where racial issues can not only be looked at on a global scale but must be addressed as such.

Before we can evaluate whether combatting the global color line will aid those in the U.S. today, we must first quantify and explore Du Bois’ observations in his own time. In 1920, he released “The Souls of White Folk,” an essay on his research into the values of the white race as a whole.² He doesn’t hold back, noting “White Christianity is a miserable failure.” Du Bois doesn’t just attack White Americans, but all of Europe. People at the time thought of World War I as an example of whites finally fighting each other rather than dominating colored areas of the

¹ (Du Bois, *The Souls of Black Folk*)

² (Du Bois, *The Souls of White Folk*)

world. Du Bois argues this is simply untrue, “The only adequate cause of this preparation was conquest and conquest, not in Europe, but primarily among the darker peoples of Asia and Africa; conquest, not for assimilation and uplift, but for commerce and degradation. For this, and this mainly, did Europe gird herself at frightful cost for war.” The implications of an event as momentous as the Great War ultimately being over the right to dominate the colored world are immense. He cites economic incentives being why it was all worth it, “Rubber, ivory, and palm-oil... — they, and a hundred other things which dark and sweating bodies hand up to the white world from pits of slime, pay and pay well, but of all that the world gets the black world gets only the pittance that the white world throws it disdainfully.” Du Bois also states, “Everything great, good, efficient, fair, and honorable is ‘white’; everything mean, bad, blundering, cheating, and dishonorable is ‘yellow’; a bad taste is ‘brown’; and the devil is ‘black.’”... “a White Man is always right and a Black Man has no rights which a white man is bound to respect.” This precisely is Du Bois’ Global Color Line, a simple dichotomy of inferiority.

So we’ve established the global color line is based on economic exploitation, and the idea of “race.” But how else was Du Bois able to back up these hypotheses? For one, he was extremely well traveled. After both world wars, Du Bois traveled to Europe to conduct research on those involved. In October of 1918, he traveled to France to interview soldiers. He mentions in some of his notes, “I talked with white officers relative to the work of the Colored soldier, in almost every instance they were referred to as cowards, rapists, or other remarks made relative to their work which were absolutely untrue, and which were intended to make a bad impression.”³ Despite the valiant war efforts of colored soldiers, their white counterparts still

³ (Du Bois, *World war I research material*)

refused to see them as equals. This only further proves Du Bois' theory of a global issue of inferiority due to race.

His ideas live on in modern times, having been interpreted in different ways by modern sociologists. Elizabeth D. Esch, a sociologist and professor at the University of Kansas published a book in 2018 titled, *The Color Line and the Assembly Line: Managing Race in the Ford Empire*, which is “a study of how, and how unevenly, the Ford Motor Company promoted both the idea of and the application of the color line to structure mass production as it expanded globally. Simultaneously, it demonstrates how... the ‘ethos of the assembly line’ was put to work in the service of white supremacist ideas and racial-segregationist practices at Ford.”⁴ Esch accuses Ford of perpetuating the global color line and reinforcing structural white supremacy. While this was likely not Henry Ford's primary goal for his empire, it may have been a nasty byproduct. Esch's description of Ford's relationship with working-class labor in his famous assembly line coincides with Du Bois' ideas about the global exploitation of colored labor. She goes on to say, “This study examines societies where Ford—the company as employer and Henry and his small coterie of managers as ideologues—was mobilized in the service of dynamics that I call ‘race development’ and ‘white managerialism’. It focuses explicitly on the white supremacist expressions and national developmentalist goals of Fordist men-making in Brazil, South Africa, and the United States.” What's important to note here is that she's not saying Ford himself built these systems elsewhere, but rather laid the groundwork for others to use his ideas to control the labor of colored colonies later in the twentieth century. It's modern studies such as this that show the immense impact of Du Bois' theory, which only gains ethos with time as others interpret his work with new research.

⁴ (Esch)

Looking at other modern examples, we can determine if his idea of a global color line still exists today, which is our next step in deciding whether an international fight against racism is practical in the twenty-first century. The existence of academic works such as Esch's Ford study already make a good case for it. If what Du Bois discussed wasn't relevant anymore, it wouldn't be featured in academic discourse as much as it still is. In a publication titled, "The Color Line, Race, and Caste: Structures of Domination and the Ethics of Recognition," James F. Keenan, a Jesuit Catholic Priest, looks at systems of discrimination in the Catholic Church, citing Du Bois as one of the earliest examples of the classifications of "race" or "color" being a defining factor of a person. "As opposed to Douglass's meaning of the color line as a discriminating line that fettered black people into a space and away from other white-dominated spaces in the United States, here Du Bois emphasized color as a global spectrum of bias. Here, the color line becomes connected with racial coloring or what will be known as colorism. Again, in 1915, Du Bois understands color as synonymous with the emerging concept of race."⁵ The theory of "color" developed by Du Bois was likely only the beginning of a topic of study that would become extremely pertinent over a hundred years later.

Keenan additionally lists other examples of modern racial injustice, "there are daily indicators of racial injustice globally, as witnessed by the tragic death of the Black Belgian, Sanda Dia, resulting from the initiation rites of his white fraternity on October 4, 2020... we will see the need to connect those racist incidents with others like the horrible rape by four upper-caste men of a nineteen-year-old Dalit woman in the Hathras district of Uttar Pradesh who died two weeks later from horrendous injuries." While many advancements for justice have been made since the early twentieth century because of leaders such as MLK, Malcolm X, and Gandhi, discrimination and cruelty continue to live on in the hearts of many. Keenan elaborates

⁵ (Keenan, J. F.)

on the cited works of Du Bois and Douglass coming to the conclusion that the issue lies in an inherent caste system defined by race. While he mainly looks at the U.S., he acknowledges that studies done outside of the border corroborate these findings. He also criticizes the Catholic Church, a white majority organization with extreme global power, for historically upholding this precedent.

We unfortunately don't have to look very hard to prove that Du Bois' color line still exists. A 2018 study conducted by UNICEF in low to middle income countries (many of them in post-colonial Africa) showed a staggering difference between advantaged and disadvantaged ethnic groups. "On average, students aged 7-14 from the most advantaged group are more than twice as likely to have foundational reading skills than those from the least advantaged group," the supporting article states.⁶ This ratio gets as bad as 4.5 times as likely in the Central African Republic and Sierra Leone. Like the U.S., Africa still feels the economic and social effects of its occupation by white oppressors. Oftentimes high tensions will exist between non-white ethnic groups in such countries due to circumstances created by the colonizers.

Clearly we as humans have a lot of work to do before we can suggest we live in a just world. But what's the best course of action? Du Bois chose the route of global efforts to combat the color line. Early success of this can be seen in a letter he received in 1951 from a manager of a company in Nigeria. He praised Du Bois for the global impact of his work on colored people, "The struggle for a place under the sun for the colored races will rise in its tempo until a man is accepted as a man globally... we feel, that you can better appreciate the humane service you shall be doing to mother Africa, and Nigeria in particular in hauling over board ruthless and heartless exploitation."⁷ This was at the time of his arrest due to his support of communism.

⁶ (UNICEF)

⁷ (P. K. Crankson & Co.)

They mention how they saw the photos of his arrest and trial which inspired them to continue their fight for justice. Just by the virtue of being a globally travelled and known figure, Du Bois had a tangible impact on global justice. For other international anti-discrimination efforts we can look no further than the United Nations. Founded during the latter part of Du Bois' career, the entire purpose of the UN is to set global standards for human treatment, an effort which still persists today. In a 2004 address to the committee, the Acting High Commissioner for Human Rights stated, "There can be no doubt that racism, racial discrimination, xenophobia and related intolerance affect millions of people throughout the world... in a time when the Internet is used to bring people together but also to spread hatred, prejudice and discrimination are rife in our midst."⁸ The latter brings up a point not yet addressed. A defining difference between our world and that of W.E.B. Du Bois is the internet and global commerce. He died in a world where international air travel was just beginning to become common. We live in a world where we can talk to someone thousands of miles away in an instant.

Societies around the globe are interconnected beyond imagination, a fact that has become crucial to global efforts for justice. For example, the topic of persecution of Uyghur muslims by the CCP has exploded on the internet, becoming a unified international discussion of condemning Authoritarian China. With the U.S. being one of the biggest shareholders of the global stage, its racial politics have also become an issue of international concern. A 2021 study conducted by Pew Research Center showed that European citizens consistently saw racial discrimination as a bigger problem in the United States than in their own country. In each country surveyed, over 80% said racial discrimination in the U.S. is a problem; 60% said it's a problem in their own nation. It's now easy to see why the Black Lives Matter movement went

⁸ (Ramcharan)

global despite starting in the U.S. It's easy for people today to get behind a movement they support, transporting politics and social movements around the globe effortlessly.

Based on this, we can come to the conclusion that anti-discrimination efforts today will never stay isolated to local regions in today's world, nor should they. Using the internet any ordinary person can turn a minor injustice into a global movement for change. We live in a time where social justice permeates the mainstream. While Du Bois would probably be disappointed in our unsuccessful attempts to end racial injustice, I imagine he'd be in awe of the tools available to us and the leaders that wield them.

Some lingering questions do still remain in regards to Du Bois, one of which is what his personal motives were throughout his life. Was he more focused on liberating African Americans or colored people on the Earth as a whole? It's likely his views changed with time, as seen in "The Negro and the Warsaw Ghetto."⁹ He notably mentioned seeing the persecution of the Jews expanded his concept of the color line beyond race, "It was not even solely a matter of color and physical and racial characteristics, which was particularly a hard thing for me to learn." This also brings up the point that everything mentioned thus far furthering the condition of colored people can and should apply to any marginalized group. The issue is no longer solely about Black Americans, but about all who have suffered discrimination. An interesting complexity of this came up in how racial discrimination exists in different forms around the world. North America focuses on race itself more than anywhere else in the world, while ethnic or religious groups elsewhere suffer from inferiority due to poverty or a lack of education. While issues should be tackled on a global scale, discrimination should not be generalized between cases. Despite the fact that W.E.B. Du Bois' global color line does still exist, but we've never been in a better place to end it.

⁹ (Du Bois, "The Negro and the Warsaw Ghetto")

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